

Glossary of Cybersecurity Terms

A short reference glossary of common cybersecurity terminology.

Authentication: The process of verifying the identity of a user, device, or system before granting access.

Authorization: The function of granting or denying specific permissions to an authenticated entity.

Confidentiality: The property that information is not disclosed to unauthorized individuals or systems.

Integrity: The property that data has not been altered or destroyed in an unauthorized manner.

Availability: The property of being accessible and usable on demand by an authorized entity.

Encryption: The process of converting plaintext into ciphertext to protect it from unauthorized reading.

Firewall: A network security device that monitors and filters incoming and outgoing traffic based on rules.

Malware: Software designed to disrupt, damage, or gain unauthorized access to a computer system.

Phishing: A social engineering attack that tricks users into revealing sensitive information via fake messages.

Vulnerability: A weakness in a system that could be exploited by a threat to cause harm.

Threat: Any circumstance or event with the potential to adversely impact organizational operations.

Risk: A measure of the extent to which an entity is threatened by a potential circumstance or event.

Patch: A software update that corrects security or functional problems in a program.

Botnet: A network of compromised computers controlled remotely by an attacker.

Ransomware: Malware that encrypts a victim's data and demands payment for the decryption key.

Zero Day: A vulnerability that is unknown to the vendor and has no available fix at the time of discovery.

Penetration Testing: An authorized simulated attack on a system to evaluate its security.

Multi Factor Authentication: An access control method requiring two or more independent verification factors.

Public Key Infrastructure: A framework of policies and technologies to manage digital certificates and keys.

Intrusion Detection System: A device or application that monitors a network for malicious activity.

Denial of Service: An attack that prevents legitimate users from accessing a system or service.

Social Engineering: The manipulation of people into performing actions or divulging confidential information.

Digital Signature: A cryptographic value that verifies the authenticity and integrity of a message.

Access Control: The selective restriction of access to a resource based on identity and policy.

Incident Response: The organized approach to addressing and managing the aftermath of a security breach.